

BREAD AND BUTTER ISSUES ARE BEGINNING TO BITE AS WOMEN—RURAL OR URBAN, EDUCATED OR NON-LITERATE, YOUNG OR OLD—COMPLAINED OF UNEMPLOYMENT AND INFLATION

or *bhajan mandlis*, doctors managing hospitals or women travellers organising spiritual tours are identified and asked to invite friends home. The Mahila Morcha workers then visit these households to engage with the gathered women and tell them about the various welfare schemes.

Opposition parties may not be able to match the BJP's phenomenal outreach, but are using their own means to connect with women voters. TMC volunteers, for instance, have been going door to door distributing an envelope/ clutch in non-woven fabric carrying the message of an increase in the flagship Lakshmir Bhandar scheme, calling it *Didir Upohar* (Mamata's gift). The Congress, too, is trying to convert the goodwill Rahul earned during his Bharat Jodo Yatras into a positive vote for the party.

Who Will Women Vote For?

With political parties engaged in competitive populism, the *ladli behnas* and the *gruha laxmis* are certainly not complaining. But will the expectation of still more handouts dictate who they vote for? "*Jiska namak khaya hai usi ko vote denge* (We will be loyal to whoever feeds us)," a group of housewives in a housing society in Agra does concede, endorsing the prime minister's women-centric schemes. Another raises the TINA factor: "*Aur hai hi kaun* (who else is there)?"

But scratch the surface and you sense disquiet, as INDIA TODAY correspondents found in their conversations with women across the country—rural or urban, educated or non-literate, young or old, Hindu or Muslim. Bread and butter issues are beginning to bite, and the lack of education and employment, as well as inflation is a recurrent theme. Ritu Dewan, former president of the Indian Association of Women's Studies, reached the same conclusion in her research among rural women. "Two prevalent themes emerged," she says. "One concerned employment opportunities for their sons, the perceived lack of growth prospects for their husbands and fear that their sons may encounter similar challenges in securing employment as they mature. Additionally, numerous primary schools are shutting down in remote regions of the country, raising concerns about the accessibility of education and its impact on future job prospects for their sons."

Will economic issues, then, be uppermost in Indian women's minds as they vote this election? Election strategist Amitabh Tiwari is not so sure. "Economic issues are perennial," he says. "They do not become a factor unless women see a credible alternative narrative." And the Opposition has yet to provide one, he feels, forcing women to invest their faith in Modi and the BJP a third time.

What will the verdict of 2024 mean for the Indian women themselves? Will it mean more handouts, ones that reinforce their gendered roles, or will they be given education and employment, and hence real empowerment? Women's representation was a dismal 15 per cent in the 17th Lok Sabha. Even in the current election, there were 358 women contestants in the first three phases, 8.6 per cent of the 4,175 candidates in the fray. There are no interest groups of women to articulate what they want as a constituency. "Why do we not have an all-woman party," asks Sirnate. "Why has that experiment never been undertaken in India despite such a huge constituency?" The male-dominated political structure needs to address these questions if women in India are to get real empowerment. ■

with **Sonal Khetarpal, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar** *and* **Siraj Qureshi** *in Agra*